

Blue Horizons Distributing and Manufacturing, Inc. v. Pristine Manufacturing and Distribution,

The public docket does not make the state-court pleading or a trade-secret designation available in this bounded review. Pristine's public company site says it provides CNC milling, turning, welding, OEM replacement parts, reverse engineering, prototypes, and full production runs. The issue map therefore concerns potential manufacturing-process, CAD/CAM, programming, tooling, quality, and independent-development questions; it does not characterize any particular information as a claimed secret.

Independent preliminary research based on public information.

FILED	FORUM	DOCKET	MATTER
2026-08-25	U.S. District Court for the District of Nebraska	8:26-cv-00468	Defend Trade Secrets Act Removal

Prepared 2026-08-27. No attorney or expert contacted. Availability, interest, compensation, and conflicts not checked.

Public filing, likely recipient, and technical frame

CAPTION	Blue Horizons Distributing and Manufacturing, Inc. v. Pristine Manufacturing and Distribution, LLC et al.
FORUM / DOCKET	U.S. District Court for the District of Nebraska / 8:26-cv-00468
FILED / TYPE	2026-08-25 / Defend Trade Secrets Act removal
PUBLIC DOCKET	Open docket

VERIFIED PUBLIC RECORD

The public docket identifies the parties, docket number 8:26-cv-00468, the August 25, 2026 filing date, the District of Nebraska, and a Defend Trade Secrets Act cause of action under 18 U.S.C. § 1836(b). It states that Christopher R. Hedican filed the notice of removal for Pristine Manufacturing and Distribution, LLC and Ryan Cronk, and lists Philip Jeffry Abraham and Nicole K. Seckman Jilek for Blue Horizons.

LIKELY RESEARCH PURCHASER

Christopher R. Hedican - Outside counsel, Baird Holm LLP. The public federal docket identifies Hedican as counsel for both defendants and as the attorney who filed the notice of removal. Treating the removal filer as a possible purchaser of expert-search research is an analytical inference, not a verified purchasing decision.

chedican@bairdholm.com - publicly printed in the [linked professional source](#); not inferred.

TECHNICAL FRAME

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Secondary-source limitation: This is preliminary public-source research. The removed state-court complaint, any trade-secret identification, and discovery must control the alleged secrets, their owners, the access pathway, and the relevant manufacturing process or product. [Open public synopsis](#)

Questions likely to require expert input

This issue map is a research plan, not a legal conclusion. The filed complaint, patent exhibits, intrinsic record, and discovery must control.

01 Identification and technical boundary of the claimed manufacturing information

What particular process instructions, CAD models, CAM programs, machining parameters, drawings, tooling specifications, inspection data, customer-part information, or workflow records does the operative pleading actually identify, and which portions were nonpublic at the relevant time?

Potential evidence: Removed complaint and exhibits; trade-secret designation; design files; CAM and CNC program versions; process sheets; drawings; access controls; repository or file-server logs; and testimony from the originating engineers or operators.

02 Independent development versus use of asserted process knowledge

Can the allegedly similar CNC milling, turning, welding, reverse-engineering, or part-production result be independently produced from a part, public engineering knowledge, standard CAD/CAM tools, customer specifications, or ordinary shop practice without using the claimed confidential information?

Potential evidence: Competing process plans; source CAD/CAM history; job travelers; machine-controller and tooling records; public technical references; reverse-engineering records; material purchase history; and reproducible shop tests.

03 CNC and CAM process provenance

Which person and system created, modified, exported, or ran each CAD model, CAM toolpath, G-code program, fixture plan, tool list, and setup instruction, and do metadata and machine records establish a reliable chronology?

Potential evidence: Native CAD/CAM files and metadata; PDM/PLM history; NC-program revisions; controller backups; machine logs; version-control records; emails; and forensic image collections.

04 Manufacturing equivalence and alternative process routes

Do the compared parts or manufacturing outcomes require the same process route, tooling, tolerances, materials, inspection sequence, and parameter choices, or could materially different routes produce the observed result?

Potential evidence: Part drawings; GD&T requirements; material certifications; tooling and fixture records; setup sheets; first-article and in-process inspection reports; CMM data; manufacturing trials; and expert comparison of process plans.

Questions likely to require expert input

05 Reverse engineering and information obtainable from the product

Which geometric, material, surface-finish, tolerance, or functional facts could be learned by measurement, inspection, teardown, or ordinary reverse engineering of an existing part, and which claimed know-how—if any—would remain undisclosed?

Potential evidence: Physical exemplars; metrology and CMM measurements; material and surface analysis; product photographs; teardown or inspection records; CAD reconstruction files; and engineering testimony.

06 Damages-related manufacturing comparison

If liability is established, what technical role did any disputed information play in lead time, scrap, quality, throughput, capacity, rework, or capability, and how can alternative causes be separated?

Potential evidence: Quotes and job-cost records; cycle-time data; scrap and rework records; quality reports; capacity and scheduling data; contemporaneous engineering plans; and comparator production runs.

Candidates 1-2 for further diligence

Ranked for preliminary research priority based on subject-matter fit, relevant public work, testimony, and visible diligence burden. This is not a retention recommendation.

01 Shreyes N. Melkote

Morris M. Bryan, Jr. Professor for Advanced Manufacturing Systems, Georgia Institute of Technology

TECHNICAL FIT

Precision machining, machine-tool systems, fixturing and handling, hybrid micromachining, and process planning are directly relevant to evaluating competing CNC manufacturing routes.

RELEVANT WORK

Georgia Tech identifies his research in precision machining and manufacturing; his group publishes on machining-process sequencing, manufacturer capability modeling, and process-aware part retrieval.

PUBLIC LITIGATION EXPERIENCE

No candidate-specific expert report, declaration, deposition, or trial testimony was located in the bounded public-source review.

POINTS FOR FURTHER DILIGENCE

The current record does not identify the claimed secret or product, so a highly specific machining focus could be broader or narrower than the eventual designation.

[Source 1](#) | [Source 2](#)

[Draft email](#) | shreyes.melkote@me.gatech.edu | [public email source](#)

02 Thomas Kurfess

Executive Director, Georgia Tech Manufacturing Institute; Professor and HUSCO/Ramirez Distinguished Chair in Fluid Power and Motion Control

TECHNICAL FIT

High-precision manufacturing, metrology, machine tools, advanced manufacturing systems, and production-system design align with process provenance and alternative-route questions.

RELEVANT WORK

Georgia Tech reports leadership roles at the Georgia Tech Manufacturing Institute and Oak Ridge National Laboratory's Manufacturing Science Division, plus research in advanced manufacturing and high-precision manufacturing/metrology systems.

PUBLIC LITIGATION EXPERIENCE

His Georgia Tech profile states that he has testified in patent cases, including at the ITC.

POINTS FOR FURTHER DILIGENCE

A broad senior-leadership portfolio may make detailed shop-floor reconstruction less central than for a candidate devoted exclusively to CNC operations.

[Source 1](#)

[Draft email](#) | kurfess@gatech.edu | [public email source](#)

Candidates 3-4 for further diligence

03 Laine Mears

Director, School of Mechanical and Automotive Engineering and SmartState Endowed Professor of Automotive Manufacturing, Clemson University

TECHNICAL FIT

Intelligent machining systems, process control, equipment diagnostics, precision positioning, difficult-to-machine materials, and industry product-launch work are relevant to testing whether a contested process was unique or reproducible.

RELEVANT WORK

Clemson describes research in intelligent machining systems and manufacturing process control, and identifies prior Tier-1/Tier-2 automotive work including hard-machining optimization and multi-spindle turning analysis.

PUBLIC LITIGATION EXPERIENCE

No candidate-specific expert report, declaration, deposition, or trial testimony was located in the bounded public-source review.

POINTS FOR FURTHER DILIGENCE

Automotive manufacturing experience may not map exactly to the parties' unknown product category or shop-scale practices.

[Source 1](#) | [Source 2](#)

[Draft email](#) | mears@clemson.edu | [public email source](#)

04 Chinedum Okwudire

Professor of Mechanical Engineering and Director, University of Michigan Advanced Manufacturing Institute

TECHNICAL FIT

Machining, manufacturing automation, smart manufacturing, precision machine design, controls, and distributed manufacturing support analysis of CNC program provenance and alternative machine/process paths.

RELEVANT WORK

Michigan identifies research applications in machining, distributed manufacturing, nano-positioning, and smart manufacturing systems, including a digital-twin optimization result for a CNC machine tool.

PUBLIC LITIGATION EXPERIENCE

No candidate-specific expert report, declaration, deposition, or trial testimony was located in the bounded public-source review.

POINTS FOR FURTHER DILIGENCE

His work emphasizes automation and controls; a materials or hands-on fabrication specialist may be needed if the designation focuses on welding metallurgy or particular material treatments.

[Source 1](#) | [Source 2](#)

[Draft email](#) | okwudire@umich.edu | [public email source](#)

Candidates 5-6 for further diligence

05 Tony L. Schmitz

Professor of Mechanical, Aerospace and Biomedical Engineering and Director, Southeastern Advanced Manufacturing Tennessee, University of Tennessee, Knoxville

TECHNICAL FIT

Machine-tool dynamics, machining process modeling, stability, performance, and experimental validation are relevant to claims of distinctive process parameters, cycle time, quality, or precision.

RELEVANT WORK

The University of Tennessee identifies him as director of an advanced-manufacturing program; his public work addresses first-principles manufacturing models, process knowledge, materials/process behavior, and experimental validation.

PUBLIC LITIGATION EXPERIENCE

No candidate-specific expert report, declaration, deposition, or trial testimony was located in the bounded public-source review.

POINTS FOR FURTHER DILIGENCE

The email source is an official university event page rather than a current individual directory page; update before retention.

[Source 1](#) | [Source 2](#)

[Draft email](#) | tony.schmitz@utk.edu | [public email source](#)

06 David W. Rosen

Professor Emeritus of Mechanical Engineering, Georgia Institute of Technology; former Director, Rapid Prototyping and Manufacturing Institute

TECHNICAL FIT

Computer-aided engineering, design and manufacturing, intelligent CAD/CAM/CAE, virtual and rapid prototyping are highly relevant to CAD/CAM files, process plans, and reverse-engineering questions.

RELEVANT WORK

Georgia Tech identifies work in computer-aided engineering, intelligent CAD/CAM/CAE, design and manufacturing, virtual prototyping, and rapid prototyping/manufacturing leadership.

PUBLIC LITIGATION EXPERIENCE

No candidate-specific expert report, declaration, deposition, or trial testimony was located in the bounded public-source review.

POINTS FOR FURTHER DILIGENCE

Emeritus status and a design/prototyping emphasis may be less aligned with a case centered on daily production-floor execution or welding.

[Source 1](#) | [Source 2](#)

[Draft email](#) | david.rosen@me.gatech.edu | [public email source](#)

Candidates 7-8 for further diligence

07 Christopher J. Saldaña

Ring Family Professor and Associate Professor, Georgia Institute of Technology

TECHNICAL FIT

Advanced manufacturing, computer-aided engineering, manufacturing metrology and process control provide a strong fit for part comparison, quality records, and process-capability questions.

RELEVANT WORK

Georgia Tech identifies research in additive/advanced manufacturing, composites, computer-aided engineering, advanced characterization, manufacturing sensors and metrology.

PUBLIC LITIGATION EXPERIENCE

No candidate-specific expert report, declaration, deposition, or trial testimony was located in the bounded public-source review.

POINTS FOR FURTHER DILIGENCE

Advanced/additive-manufacturing emphasis may not be central if the dispute is confined to conventional CNC machining or commercial customer information.

[Source 1](#) | [Source 2](#)

[Draft email](#) | christopher.saldana@me.gatech.edu | [public email source](#)

08 Aaron P. Stebner

Associate Professor of Mechanical Engineering and Materials Science and Engineering, Georgia Institute of Technology

TECHNICAL FIT

Manufacturing, machine learning, mechanics, materials, automation technologies, and industrial IoT can help assess whether material/process information or a manufacturing workflow is technically distinctive.

RELEVANT WORK

Georgia Tech describes work at the intersection of manufacturing, machine learning, materials, mechanics, industrial IoT, NASA smart-materials research, and prior manufacturing/automation engineering.

PUBLIC LITIGATION EXPERIENCE

No candidate-specific expert report, declaration, deposition, or trial testimony was located in the bounded public-source review.

POINTS FOR FURTHER DILIGENCE

Materials and advanced-manufacturing framing may be a secondary fit if the alleged secret turns out to be a narrow customer list or ordinary commercial information.

[Source 1](#)

[Draft email](#) | aaron.stebner@gatech.edu | [public email source](#)

Candidates 9-10 for further diligence

09 Rahul Rai

Professor of Automotive Engineering, Clemson University; Director, Geometric Reasoning and Artificial Intelligence Lab

TECHNICAL FIT

Manufacturing engineering, geometric reasoning, AI, and industrial research experience can assist with CAD reconstruction, design/process comparison, and whether information could be recreated from a physical part or available data.

RELEVANT WORK

Clemson reports manufacturing-engineering degrees and leadership of the Geometric Reasoning and Artificial Intelligence Lab, with prior research-center experience at United Technology Research Center and PARC.

PUBLIC LITIGATION EXPERIENCE

No candidate-specific expert report, declaration, deposition, or trial testimony was located in the bounded public-source review.

POINTS FOR FURTHER DILIGENCE

Geometry/AI orientation may not cover the full factual question of trade-secret access and operational shop practice without a complementary machining expert.

[Source 1](#)

[Draft email](#) | rrai@clemson.edu | [public email source](#)

10 John W. Sutherland

Distinguished Professor and Fehsenfeld Family Head of Sustainability Engineering and Environmental Engineering, Purdue University

TECHNICAL FIT

Smart and sustainable manufacturing, manufacturing planning, remanufacturing, recycling, process impacts, and industrial cost/efficiency metrics are relevant to alternative process routes and technical damages questions.

RELEVANT WORK

Purdue identifies research in environmentally responsible design and manufacturing, closed-loop material cycles, remanufacturing, manufacturing-process efficiency, and sustainable manufacturing planning.

PUBLIC LITIGATION EXPERIENCE

No candidate-specific expert report, declaration, deposition, or trial testimony was located in the bounded public-source review.

POINTS FOR FURTHER DILIGENCE

Sustainability/manufacturing-systems focus is less specific to CNC program authorship or trade-secret forensic analysis.

[Source 1](#) | [Source 2](#)

[Draft email](#) | jwsuther@purdue.edu | [public email source](#)

Preliminary candidates; no conflicts or availability determination

- Run party, affiliate, counsel, inventor, funder, and technology conflicts.
- Confirm testimony history, exclusions, compensation, publications, patents, and deposition performance.
- Investigate licensing, grants, consulting, commercial interests, and prior technical positions.
- Confirm role fit, availability, and interest only after counsel authorizes outreach.

ONGOING MATTER-SPECIFIC RESEARCH

Flint Witness Research works in the post-filing window, turning pleadings and public technical records into issue maps, researched candidate slates, and diligence starting points as the case develops.

[Schedule a 15-minute conversation](#)

CORE SOURCES

Public docket: <https://dockets.justia.com/docket/nebraska/nedce/8%3A2026cv00468/112740>

Public professional email source: <https://www.bairdholm.com/wp-content/uploads/2022/05/The-Ethics-of-Settlement-Negotiation.pdf>

Public technical context source: <https://pristinemanufacturing.com/>

LIMITATIONS

This is preliminary public-source research. The removed state-court complaint, any trade-secret identification, and discovery must control the alleged secrets, their owners, the access pathway, and the relevant manufacturing process or product.

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